Q. What about better preparedness at the LAC?
That's another major lesson from Galwan: the importance of preparedness and sustained deployment capability. Over the past few years, we have carried out a major rebalancing of forces towards the northern borders. That has involved the deployment of additional infantry, armour, aviation assets, logistics support, ammunition stocking, habitat creation and infrastructure development for long-duration deployment in high-altitude areas. Large quantities of reserves, rations, ammunition and winter stocking had to be created and sustained. We also validated several operational concepts through exercises and deployments over multiple winters. At the same time, our surveillance and information systems have improved significantly. Infrastructure development along the border has accelerated, mobility has improved and our ability to monitor developments in real time is far stronger today. The overall level of preparedness, operationally and logistically, is much higher now. The effort to strengthen infrastructure and capabilities along the northern borders is continuing.

Q. What are the other major learnings from these two conflicts—with Pakistan, and earlier, with China?
One is that warfare is shifting rapidly. Earlier warfare was platform-centric—tanks, aircraft and ships operating largely in separate domains. Today, warfare is network-centric. There are sensors everywhere—satellites, UAVs, mobile phones, cameras, civilian infrastructure—and they enable us to strike with greater precision and speed. The battlefield has become transparent. We are now transitioning from network-centric warfare to data-centric warfare and eventually toward AI-driven intelligent warfare. AI will increasingly assist commanders by analysing historical data, predicting outcomes and helping decision-making. The battlefield is no longer confined to land, sea and air. Warfare now includes cyber, space, information and cognitive domains. Air warfare itself has expanded vertically—from low-altitude drone warfare to hypersonic systems operating near space. Maritime warfare includes seabed warfare. Urban and subterranean warfare has become a critical lesson from conflicts like Gaza. At the same time, lower airspace has become saturated with drones, loitering munitions and autonomous systems. Beyond the physical domains, entirely new battlefronts have emerged—cyber, space, information warfare and the cognitive domain. Modern conflict is increasingly being fought not only in the physical realm, but also in the informational, digital and psychological realms. If our armed forces fail to adapt rapidly to these changes, they risk becoming obsolete. Our greatest challenge today, therefore, is not merely acquiring new systems, but also understanding these changes, integrating technologies across services, educating personnel and building a coherent roadmap for the future.

Q. There is also a concern about low-cost drones being used against high-value military assets. How is India adapting to this challenge?
That is a very important point. The cost asymmetry is real—relatively inexpensive drones can potentially threaten high-value targets if not properly countered. Earlier, air bases and forward infrastructure were built keeping in mind the range of aircraft and missiles of that era. But today, the reach of long-range missiles and drones has increased significantly. This changes the entire logic of base location, protection and survivability. We cannot simply relocate infrastructure at will. Airfields, logistics hubs and operational bases are tied to geography, terrain and strategic requirements. The answer is not just mobility, but resilience. We need a layered approach. First, a robust counter-UAS (Unmanned Aerial System) and air defence network that can detect, track and neutralise incoming drones and aerial threats. This must be integrated across multiple layers of surveillance and weapon systems. Second,



> **"Warfare is shifting from being platform-centric—tanks, aircraft and ships operating separately—to being fought in the cyber, information, space and cognitive domains**
>
> **Jointness is first a mindset, integration comes later. As warfighting becomes extremely complex, no single service can fight effectively in isolation anymore"**